

SOVEREIGN

Govern Your Attention

Full Project Specification

Philosophy · Architecture · Implementation

Version 0.3, June 2026

Reclaim the right to be unreachable.

*This is not for those who hunger for connection.
It is for those who have forgotten what it feels like to be without it.*

PART I: THE MANIFESTO

Sovereign: A Manifesto for Attention

There is a moment most of us have lived but rarely name.

You are sitting across from someone you love. They are speaking. And your hand, almost without your permission, reaches for your phone.

Not because anything important happened. Not because you were bored. But because the habit is deeper than intention now. The device has become the default state. Presence has become the effort.

This is not an accident.

The Agreement You Never Signed

Somewhere in the last decade, a quiet agreement was made on your behalf. The agreement said: you will be available. Always. To everyone. Instantly.

You didn't sign it. But you accepted it, because everyone did. Because the tools that connected you to the people you love also connected you to everything else, and separating them seemed impossible.

The algorithm understood this before you did. Your attention, your most finite and most personal resource, became a commodity. Bought and sold in milliseconds. Packaged and delivered to advertisers while you scrolled, refreshed, checked, and scrolled again.

They called it connection. It was extraction.

What Sovereign Is Not

We are not anti-technology. We are not asking you to move to a cabin, abandon your WhatsApp, or explain to your mother why she can't reach you anymore.

We understand that digital infrastructure is real infrastructure. That your bank lives in an app. That your work runs on notifications. That the people you love are on platforms you didn't choose but can't leave.

We are not fighting that world. We are learning to govern our place in it.

Sovereign is not for those who hunger for connection. It is for those who have forgotten what it feels like to be without it.

The Right to Be Unreachable

| You have the right to be unreachable.

Not forever. Not from everyone. But on your terms. At your pace. By your choice.

The right to finish a meal without an interruption that wasn't urgent. The right to wake up slowly, without the world's demands already waiting on your nightstand. The right to be bored, genuinely and productively bored, and let your mind wander somewhere the algorithm can't follow.

These are not luxuries. They are the conditions of a human life.

What Sovereign Is

Sovereign is a self-hosted personal communication router. It sits between you and your digital world, evaluates every incoming message, and either delivers it to your dumb phone as an SMS or holds it in the Vault until you choose to engage.

It is self-hosted because no company should own the infrastructure of your attention. It is open source because the community should govern what governs them. It is free because sovereignty should not require a subscription.

Sovereign. Govern your attention.

PART II: THE VOCABULARY

Every term was chosen because it reinforces the philosophy. Use these consistently across documentation, community communication, and the interface.

Term	Meaning
The Council	Your VIP list. Small by design, soft cap of 10. Their messages always reach you, skipping every other check.
The Decrees	Your rules. IF [condition] THEN [pass/hold]. Priority-ordered; lower number checked first; first match wins.
The Advisor	Local AI behavioral model (Ollama). Learns from your response patterns. Never reads message content. Never cloud inference.
The Vault	Everything held. Two tabs: Waiting and Retrieved. Nothing is ever deleted.
The Chronicle	Read-only, honest log of every Sovereign decision. Pass/hold, which gate called it, when. No gamification.
The Realm	Your Sovereign instance. Your config, your data, your rules.
The Territory	Your dumb phone. The calm device that is your primary interface with the world.
The Commonwealth	The Sovereign community sharing Decrees, insights, and hardware guides.

PART III: THE ARCHITECTURE

Sovereign is a personal communication router. All seven layers are fully implemented and shipped.

```
LAYER 1 : Ingestion           - platform connectors normalize all messages
Urgency Engine               - three-tier evaluation: Council -> Decrees -> Advisor
Delivery                     - SMS formatter, quiet hours, multi-gateway support
Reply Routing                 - SMS commands routed back to originating platform
Advisor                      - local Ollama behavioral model
browser-only React UI (six rooms)
LAYER 2 : The Interface      -
LAYER 3 : Deployment         - Docker Compose,
                             setup script, Makefile
LAYER 4 :
LAYER 5 :
LAYER 6 :
LAYER 7 :
```

Layer 1: Ingestion

Each connector normalizes incoming messages into a single internal schema. The urgency engine never knows which platform sent a message.

How people reach you on each platform:

Platform	Method	Status	Invisible to sender?
WhatsApp	mautrix-whatsapp Matrix bridge	Done	Yes - they message your real number
Instagram	mautrix-meta Matrix bridge	Done	Yes - they DM your real account
Email	IMAP IDLE	Done	Yes - they email your real address
SMS	Twilio webhook	Done	Yes - they text your number
Telegram	Official Bot API (polling)	Done	No - they message your bot, not your personal account
Facebook Messenger	mautrix-meta (messenger mode)	Same bridge, not yet enabled	Yes

Important Telegram distinction: Telegram works through a bot account separate from your personal Telegram. People reach you by messaging your bot, not your real handle. The bot only sees group messages if added to the group with privacy disabled via BotFather.

Matrix Bridge Architecture (WhatsApp and Instagram)

WhatsApp and Instagram are bridged through a private Matrix homeserver (Synapse) plus mautrix bridges. This keeps the real you reachable while Sovereign filters transparently.

```
WhatsApp <-> mautrix-whatsapp <-> Synapse (Matrix homeserver) <-> Sovereign
connectorInstagram <-> mautrix-meta <-> Synapse (Matrix homeserver) <->
Sovereign connector
```

Key behaviors to understand:

- Portal rooms are created on demand. A chat appears only when it next receives a message. The first message in a brand-new chat may be missed; the next comes through.
- WhatsApp bridge stays linked like a WhatsApp Web companion. The phone must go online occasionally; WhatsApp unlinks idle companions after approximately 14 days.
- Instagram uses session cookies via the unofficial API. Instagram can challenge or disable the account. Enable 2FA to reduce blocks.
- The same Synapse homeserver and Sovereign connector handle both WhatsApp and Instagram. No connector changes needed when adding Instagram.

Layer 2: The Urgency Engine

Every incoming message is evaluated through three tiers in sequence. The first tier that claims urgency wins. If none does, the message goes to the Vault.

Tier 1: The Council

The Council is checked before any Decree at all. A Council member's message always reaches you, including from a group, regardless of any Decree priority. The clean way to let one important person through group noise is to add them to the Council rather than reshuffling Decrees.

Per-member configuration: each Council member has an optional quiet hours override toggle (always deliver, even during quiet hours). This is the per-person exception that sits above the global quiet hours setting.

Tier 2: The Decrees

Rules are priority-ordered. Lower number is checked earlier. First match wins, then evaluation stops. New Decrees default to priority 50. Leave gaps (10, 20, 30) so rules can be slotted between existing ones without renumbering.

Three default Decrees ship with every new Realm:

Priority	Name	Condition	Action
1	Hold all group messages	Message is in a group	HOLD - always, no override
10	Urgency keywords	emergency, urgent, hospital, accident, llamame, ayuda, please call	PASS

20	Frequency escalation	Same sender 3+ messages in 10 minutes	PASS
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Because Hold all group messages sits at priority 1, a group message is held before the keyword check at 10 ever runs. A group message containing an urgency keyword still waits in the Vault. To let one specific person through a group, add them to the Council (Tier 1 is checked before any Decree).

In direct chats, urgency keywords pass the message even if the sender is not in the Council. The group-hold Decree only applies to group chats.

Tier 3: The Advisor

A local AI model that watches what you do after Sovereign makes a decision. It tracks which held messages you rush to open and which passed messages you ignore. It never reads message content. Sender names are stored as scrambled codes.

Level	Name	When	Behavior
0	Silent	Weeks 1-2	Observing only. Makes no decisions.
1	Suggesting	Weeks 3-4	Surfaces gentle suggestions in the Advisor room.
2	Advising	Month 2+	Regular recommendations with full data shown.
3	Refining	Month 4+	Auto-adjusts weights (opt-in only).
4	Sovereign	Month 6+	Fully personalized. Near-zero false signals.

Core Guardrail

Sovereign never silently drops a message. Every message either passes through or is held in the Vault. Nothing is deleted. Nothing is lost.

Layer 3: Delivery

Urgent messages are formatted as SMS and delivered to your dumb phone. Every SMS follows a compressed, contextual format:

```
[WA] Mama: Llamame cuando puedas, es importante[TG] Carlos: Emergency at the
office, need you now[EM] Dr. Rodriguez: Your results are ready, please call[WA]
Carlos: 4 messages in 8 min
```

SMS Gateways

Sovereign supports four SMS delivery gateways. Auto-detected in order: twilio -> infinireach -> android -> gammu. Override with the SMS_GATEWAY environment variable.

Gateway	Who it is for	Key detail
twilio	Quickest start	Set TWILIO_* credentials. Standard cloud long code.
infinireach	No USB modem; want hosted relay via your own SIM	INFINIREACH_API_KEY. Inbound replies need a public webhook. Local-to-local SMS avoids A2P filtering in countries like Colombia.
android	No USB modem; prefer fully local LAN setup	An Android phone with a SIM running an HTTP SMS-gateway app. Set ANDROID_SMS_GATEWAY_URL, USER, PASS. Local-to-local; no A2P filtering.
gammu	Full sovereignty	USB GSM modem + GAMMU_CONFIG_PATH. SMS from your own physical SIM. No third party.

Note on Colombia and similar markets: cloud long codes from Twilio and other US/EU providers are subject to A2P filtering in some countries that blocks foreign numbers. InfiniReach and the Android gateway both use a phone's local SIM, making SMS local-to-local and avoiding this filter.

Quiet Hours

Configured in the Settings room. During quiet hours, urgent messages wait until the window ends instead of reaching the phone. Two exceptions always break through: Council members with their individual quiet hours override enabled, and the flood override (configurable: N urgent messages within M minutes triggers delivery regardless).

Layer 4: Reply Routing

When an urgent message reaches the dumb phone, there is a 15-minute reply window. The user simply texts back a reply and Sovereign routes it to the correct person on the correct platform. To them, it is a completely normal conversation.

After the window expires, or for vault management, SMS commands are available:

Command	What happens
r Sounds good, call you back	Reply to the most recent urgent message
r mama I'll be home soon	Reply to the last message from the contact named mama
r 2 On my way	Reply to the 2nd most recent message
list	See a numbered list of recent held messages
read 3	Read the full content of message 3

status	Get a quick vault summary
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Sovereign sends a confirmation SMS back after each command.

Layer 5: The Advisor

Runs locally via Ollama. Never cloud inference. Behavioral patterns never leave the user's machine. Sender names stored as scrambled codes, never plaintext. Message content never stored or analyzed.

The user can reset the Advisor to zero at any time from the Advisor room. No confirmation prompt, no data retained.

Layer 6: The Interface

Browser-only React UI. Never an app. Accessed with intention. Password-protected (no usernames, no accounts, just the user). Changing the password signs out any other active device.

Six rooms:

Room	Purpose	Notes
The Vault	Held messages in two tabs: Waiting and Retrieved	Opening a message moves it to Retrieved and signals the Advisor. No notification badges.
The Council	VIP list management	Per-member quiet hours override toggle. Soft cap reminder at 10 members.
The Decrees	Priority-ordered rules	Lower number = checked first. First match wins. Default three Decrees ship with every Realm.
The Advisor	AI pattern suggestions	Shows maturity level, accuracy, false passes, missed urgents. Reset available at any time.
The Chronicle	Read-only decision log	Pass/hold per message, which gate called it. No scores, no streaks.
Settings	Quiet hours and flood override	Global quiet hours window, timezone, per-person exceptions live in Council.

Onboarding: on first load after password setup, Sovereign asks one question: who should always reach you? This builds the initial Council. No feature tours, no tooltip overlays.

Layer 7: Deployment

Sovereign has one deployment model: self-hosted. There is no managed cloud tier. There is no subscription. That is not a missing feature. It is the point.

No company should own the infrastructure of your attention. That includes us.

Quick Start

```
git clone https://github.com/staysovereign/sovereign-stack.git cd
sovereign./setup.sh # generates secrets, checks prerequisites#
Edit .env with your valuesdocker compose up -dmake ollama-pull # pull
the Ollama model (runs in background)
```

Open the interface at <http://localhost>. On first load, set a password, then build your Council.

With WhatsApp and Instagram (Matrix bridges)

```
./setup.sh --whatsapp # prepares shared Synapse config# Follow the Matrix
Bridge Setup guide (docs/WHATSAPP_SETUP.md)docker compose --profile whatsapp up -d
```

Always start the stack with the whatsapp profile when bridges are configured, so Synapse and the bridges run alongside the core stack.

Hardware Options

Option	Cost	Notes
VPS (2GB RAM, 20GB SSD)	~5 EUR/month	Recommended for most users. Fastest to start.
Home server or old laptop	One-time	Always-on required.
Raspberry Pi 4 + USB GSM modem + SIM	~60 EUR one-time	Full sovereignty. SMS from your own SIM via gammu. No Twilio.

Common Operations

```
make logs # tail all service logsmake status # show running
containers and healthmake backup # dump SQLite DB to ./backups/make
update # pull latest images and rebuildmake ollama-pull # pull the
Ollama LLM modelmake whatsapp-qr # tail bridge logs (WhatsApp pairing /
login)make up-whatsapp # start full stack with WhatsApp profile
```

Minimum Viable Configuration

```
DUMB_PHONE_NUMBER=+1234567890TELEGRAM_BOT_TOKEN=your-bot-tokenTWILIO_ACCOUNT_SID=ACxxxTWILIO_AUTH_TOKEN=xxxTWILIO_PHONE_NUMBER=+1987654321
```

PART IV: TECHNOLOGY STACK

Component	Technology	Notes
Core engine	Python 3.12 + FastAPI	
Platform connectors	Node.js 22 + Express	
WhatsApp bridge	mautrix-whatsapp (Go, bridgev2)	Modern bridgev2 format. Config must be generated, not hand-written.
Instagram bridge	mautrix-meta (Go, Instagram mode)	Same Synapse. Appservice port 29319.
Database	SQLite (WAL mode)	Single database for the Sovereign core. Synapse uses its own SQLite.
AI / Advisor	Ollama (local LLM)	Never cloud inference. Behavioral data stays local.
SMS gateway	Twilio / InfiniReach / Android HTTP / gammu	Auto-detected. Override with SMS_GATEWAY env var.
Interface	React + Vite	Password-protected. Browser-only. Six rooms.
Deployment	Docker Compose + setup.sh + Makefile	WhatsApp/Instagram via --profile whatsapp.
License	AGPL-3.0	Anyone can run it, modify it, must keep modifications open source.

PART V: SUSTAINABILITY

Sovereign has no subscription revenue. That is intentional. The project sustains itself through models that do not create dependency or conflict of interest.

Model	What it is
Open Collective / GitHub Sponsors	Community funds development directly and transparently. Every euro visible. No strings.
Raspberry Pi bundles	Pre-configured hardware shipped ready to run. Ship the sovereignty, not the service.
Integration consulting	Paid setup and support for organizations deploying Sovereign for their teams. No access to their data. Time for money.
Community documentation	staysovereign.io as the knowledge hub. The site serves users, not investors.

PART VI: LAUNCH SEQUENCE

Phase	When	Status	What
Phase 0. Founder	Now	In progress	Self as first user. Document everything: setup, friction, surprises, first week of held messages.
Phase 1. Private Beta	Month 1-2	Next	20 to 30 people from personal network. No press. No hype. Honest testers who feel the problem.
Phase 2. Community Release	Month 3-4	Planned	Repository published publicly. Manifesto published. Self-hosted path documented. staysovereign.io community opens.
Phase 3. Movement	Ongoing	Planned	Community contributes Decrees. Advisor library grows. Hardware guides multiply. Translations appear.

PART VII: KEY DECISIONS LOG

Decision	Choice Made	Rationale
Deployment model	Self-hosted only, no managed cloud	Offering a managed cloud tier creates a structural contradiction. Asking people to trust a third party with the infrastructure of their attention recreates the problem in a different shape.
WhatsApp connector	mautrix-whatsapp (bridgev2) over Baileys	Lower ban risk for personal human-paced use. Baileys emulates bot behavior; mautrix emulates web client behavior. Uses modern bridgev2 format.
Instagram connector	mautrix-meta over scraping	Same Synapse reused. Reuses existing Sovereign connector. Risk acknowledged: unofficial API, session cookies, Instagram can challenge.
Telegram connector	Bot API, not personal account bridge	Official, stable, zero ban risk. Trade-off: contacts message the bot, not the personal account.
Database	SQLite (WAL mode) instead of PostgreSQL	Simpler for single-user self-hosted deployment. Sufficient for the load. Easier backup (make backup).
SMS gateways	Four options: Twilio, InfiniReach, Android HTTP, gammu	Addresses A2P filtering reality in markets like Colombia where foreign cloud numbers are blocked. Local SIM options solve this.
AI inference	Local Ollama only, never cloud	Behavioral patterns never leave the user's machine. Non-negotiable.
Interface	Six rooms including Settings, browser-only	Settings room handles quiet hours and flood override. Password protection with no username system. Never an app.
Revenue	Open Collective + consulting + hardware bundles	No subscription means no conflict of interest between growth and user sovereignty.
Domain	staysovereign.io	Stay sovereign is a directive. Assumes the user already understands the value and is committing to it. sovereign.io and all obvious variants were taken.
Repository	github.com/staysovereign/sovereign-stack	Current location. To be moved to github.com/staysovereign when organization is created.

PART VIII: KNOWN BEHAVIORS AND LIMITATIONS

Documented behaviors that are expected and by design, not bugs.

Behavior	Context	Detail
First message in new WhatsApp/Instagram chat may be missed	Matrix bridges	Portal rooms are created on demand. The connector joins a moment after the room is created. The second message comes through normally.
WhatsApp session expires after ~14 days of phone inactivity	mautrix-whatsapp	The bridge stays linked like a WhatsApp Web companion. The phone must connect to the internet at least once every 14 days or the session is unlinked.
Pairing code must be entered within ~60 seconds	WhatsApp setup	Entering the code late triggers a known bridge refresh bug. Simply re-run the pairing step for a fresh code.
Group messages are held even if they contain urgency keywords	Urgency engine	The Hold all group messages Decree sits at priority 1, checked before the keyword Decree at priority 10. This is intentional. Add the sender to Council to let them through from groups.
Instagram contacts have no phone number	mautrix-meta	Match Council members by their bridge ID (@meta_...) rather than phone. Easiest after they have messaged once (visible in Chronicle).
Telegram only sees group messages if bot is added and privacy disabled	Telegram connector	Via BotFather: /setprivacy -> your bot -> Disable. Without this, the bot only sees @mentions and replies.
Large Instagram first sync creates many portals	mautrix-meta	Connector paces its joins to stay under Synapse rate limits. Expected behavior during initial setup.
Email startup backlog behavior	Email connector	EMAIL_STARTUP_SCAN_LIMIT controls how many pre-existing unseen messages are processed on boot. Default 10. Set to 0 to skip backlog entirely. Mail arriving after startup is always processed live.

CLOSING NOTE

Version 0.3 reflects the state of a working, deployed system. All seven architectural layers are complete. The project moved from concept to code.

What was designed in a single session as philosophy first, technology second has been built exactly in that order. Every technical decision traces back to the manifesto. The core guardrail remains non-negotiable: nothing is ever silently dropped.

The next chapter is Phase 1: putting it in the hands of 20 to 30 real people who felt that feeling.

This is not for those who hunger for connection. It is for those who have forgotten what it feels like to be without it.

SOVEREIGN

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staysovereign.io · github.com/staysovereign/sovereign-stack